PART : IV

SOCIAL INEQUALITY

Chapter 20

SOCIAL DIFFERENTIATION AND SOCIAL STRATIFICATION

Social Differentiation: Causes of Differentiation–Distribution of Differences in Society on the Basis of Sex, Age, and Occupation–Social Stratification: Meaning and Characteristics–Origin of Social Stratification–Social Stratification and Social Mobility–Functions of Social Stratification.

In all societies there is differentiation of the population by age, sex, and personal characteristics. The roles and privileges of children differ from those of adults; and those of good hunters or warriors differ from those of the rank and file. It is not customary to speak of a society as stratified if every individual in it has an equal chance to succeed to whatever statuses are open. Strictly speaking, there are no purely equalitarian societies, only societies differing in degree of stratification. Even Russia which dreamt of a 'classless society', could not, any more than any other society escape the necessity of ranking people according to their functions. The criteria of rank have changed along with values of society. "*Unstratified society with real equality of its members, is a myth that has never been realised in the history of mankind* – [*P.A. Sorokin*]. All societies exhibit some system of hierarchy whereby its members are placed in positions that are higher or lower, superior or inferior, in relation to each other. The concept of '*social stratification*' is made use of to refer to such classification or gradation and placement of people in society. Through this process of stratification people are *fixed* in the social structure of the society. Stratification assumes three main forms: *caste, estates* and *class*.

A. SOCIAL DIFFERENTIATION

1. MEANING AND CAUSES OF SOCIAL DIFFERENTIATION

Society Rests on Differences

Everywhere individuals and societies differ. In no society people are absolutely equal in all respects. Differentiation is the keynote of human society. Society rests on the principle of difference. Differences are inherent in the very nature of the society. In all societies there is social differentiation

of the population by *age, sex, occupation and personal characteristics*. There are the major factors of social differentiation. Men and women, teenagers and adults, children and old men, masters and servants, managers and attendants, rulers and ruled, teachers and the taught, rich and the poor, literate and the illiterate, engineers and doctors, teachers and advocates, shopkeepers and hotel-owners are not always adjudged as equal. There are no equalitarian societies in the world. Societies are marked by differentiation. Societies may only differ in the *degree* of differentiation and *nature* of stratification.

Differences in Different Fields

Some type of differentiation or specialisation of role is found in practically every society. It is clearly related to the rise and operation of social classes. In the *economic order*, differentiation is found in the different roles of entrepreneur, manager, and skilled and unskilled labourers. It is evident in the *professions*; in the *political order* as witnessed in the varying roles of public administrators, legislators, and judges; in *education* as between teachers and administrators; and in *religion*, as in the distinct roles of prophet, seer and priest. In reality, some form of specialisation of the role is found in every association of men.

Causes of Differentiation

Talcott Parsons mentions three causal factors of social differentiation – (*i*) *possession*, (*ii*) *qualities*, and (*iii*) *performance*. These three are, however, interrelated.

Possession refers to mainly material possessions, such as money, wealth, property, and all the other valuable, utilitarian material objects. People do not have equal access to these possessions. The unequal distribution of these material possessions has contributed to inequality and differentiation.

Qualities refers to the intrinsic capacities or abilities of people to undertake or to do a task. These qualities are also not equally distributed. For example, physical strength, intelligence, 'beauty', courage, loyalty to a cause, moral courage, industriousness, selflessness, sacrifice and other internal qualities are not equally distributed. People are ranked differently depending upon the degree of possession of these qualities.

Performance refers to the execution of a task in a given time under a given situation. Performances are always judged *first* according to their products or results. *Secondly*, they are judged according to the manner and style of the performing. Performances are always subject to regulatory norms. When the norms are violated, performances are often disvalued, regardless of their results.

Possessions, qualities and performances are closely related. Material possessions like wealth may help a man to develop his qualities which may better his performance. Similarly qualities may help a man to make possessions or to acquire material possessions. We should note that a person's qualities, possessions and performances are usually judged in relation to his age and with references to a particular social role. Not only persons but also groups are ranked according to the merit of their imputed qualities and performances. The term '*prestige*' is used to refer to the approval, respect, admiration, or deference a person or group is able to command by virtue of his or its imputed qualities or performances. The term '*ranking*' is generally used to refer to the degree of prestige. The term '*stratification*' denotes the process or condition in which layers [strata] of persons or groups are ranked differently. Any one stratum contains many persons or groups of roughly the same rank. Standards of evaluation vary from one social system to another, and from one situation to another within the same social system.

2. DISTRIBUTION OF DIFFERENCES IN SOCIETY ON THE BASIS OF AGE, SEX AND OCCUPATION

Differentiation Based on Sex

Differentiation based on sex is one of the most fundamental features of human society. There are only *two sexes*, *male* and *female* – not one, not three – and this is one of the brute facts of the universe. The existence of two sexes, a biological differentiation, results in what is also one of the

most important kinds of social differentiation. In no society males and females do the same things, occupy the same statuses, share identical interests, conform to the same norms, or aspire to the same kinds of achievement. All societies canalise the conduct of the sexes in different directions, just as they signalise the difference by the distinction in dress. No society treats its men and its women exactly alike. In all societies they think differently, and do different kinds of work. Some writers have even spoken of 'male culture' and 'female culture' to denote their diverse way of life. In any event, it is certain that the biological fact of sexual differentiations has manifold social consequences.

Sexual Differentiation is Cultural Also. It is wrong to presume that sexual differentiation is basically a biological and not a cultural one. It is cultural also. The male is not the dominant sex everywhere. There are communities wherein female is the dominant sex. In such communities women initiate sexual behaviour. They are the aggressors in courtship and they only make the marital decisions. In such communities prostitution is a male and not a female institution. If we are male, our society bends our conduct in one way; if we are female, in another. How much of this difference is due to nature, how much to culture? This question is answered differently by different thinkers.

Women – The Weaker Sex? The general belief everywhere is that man is the *dominant sex* and the woman is the *weaker sex*. The woman is called the *second sex*. The philosopher *Nietzsche* regarded women as the '*God's second mistake*'. *Robert Bierstedt* writes: 'In all societies it is woman who has been subject and slave; man who has been ruler and master. Woman is vessal, receptacle, utensil. She is conquered, subdued, vanquished, in sexual encounter as in life. Man takes, woman gives; man acts, woman waits'. *Plato* thanked God for he had been born free and not a slave and that he was a man and not a woman. *St. Paul* concluded that "*the man is not of the woman; but the woman of the man. Neither was the man created for the woman: but the woman for the man*".

It is significant to note that *women have greater immunity to diseases than men*. The rate of infant mortality is comparatively less in women than in men. In a way, man is a weaker sex. The general belief is that men are more intelligent and do greater achievements than women. *Robert Bierstedt* writes that '*men of genuine distinction appear in positive profusion in comparison with women of distinction*'. *Margaret Mead* writes: 'A woman's life is punctuated by a series of specific events: the beginning of physical maturity ....., the end of virginity, pregnancy and birth, and finally, the menopause.... Sex in its whole meaning, from courtship through parenthood, means more to women than it does to men'. 'Indeed, a woman is always reminded that 'A woman can never forget her sex'.

Age Differentiation

All societies differentiate their members on the ground of age also. In no society the same norms govern the behaviour of the very young, the very old and the adult members in the same way. Age, as a biological factor contributes to social differentiation. *It distributes privileges and responsibilities, rights and duties*, in terms of separate statuses. Age statuses, like sex statuses, *are ascribed* and *not achieved*. In almost all the societies the following age groups are recognised: 1. *Infancy*, 2. *Childhood*, 3. *Adolescence*, 4. *Adulthood*, and 5. *Old Age*. In some societies, the *unborn* and the *dead individuals* are also given some importance.

Age Grading. *Age stratification or age grading* is here in all the societies. Thus one has to attain a certain age in order to go to school, to join a church, to be considered responsible (or a 'major') in a court of law, to sign a valid contract, to be guilty of a crime, to vote, to marry, to earn a commission in the armed services, to sit in the Parliament, and so on through an entire roster of abilities and disabilities. We expect people to conform to the norms attached to their age statuses. We become surprised and sometimes shocked when deviations take place from this. When an old man marries a young woman, for example, or vice versa, we tend to respond with some discomfort. It becomes the 'new', it may become even scandal.

Age and Social Expectations. Further, our social expectations are also woven around different ages. We do not expect college students to be in their fifties, their professors in their teens. Workers may not like to have a 'boss' who is considerably younger to them. Definitely, certain ages are right for certain activities and wrong for others. We expect people to occupy certain statuses at definite stages in their lives. Seniority is a factor in all associational life, whether in business, the army, the university, or elsewhere.

Finally, people who associate with one another informally also tend to segregate themselves in terms of age. For the very young, a difference of a year to two is a very large difference. In a college a final year student, *i.e.*, a senior student may not like to have close friendship with the fresh students. Later on, differences in age of ten years or more may seem very little. Outside of families, intimacies rarely develop among people of different generations. The factor of age is rarely neglected in social intercourse. Neither can it be ignored in sociology. '*Like sex differentiation, it (age) is one of the ties that bind people together as well as one of the barriers that keep them apart'.–Robert Bierstedt.*

Occupational Differentiation

Age and sex differences are no doubt obvious foundations of specialisation everywhere. So *too different occupations create conditions for variation in roles and statuses*. At the same time, they foster *interdependence* also. An occupation is more than simply a way of earning money. It is an *index and symbol of the style* that people live and the *level of prestige* that is accorded to them by others. The concept of '*occupation*' is more or less appropriate for most modern industrialised societies. But it is less appropriate in many primitive and traditionalistic societies. In every society there is some degree for role differentiation according to function, whether this differentiation is 'occupational' or not. It is significant to note that occupation is the most used measure of class system.

Occupational Ranking. One of the best-known attempts to rank occupations in the U.S.A. was made by *P.K. Hatt* and *C.C. North*. In this test a nationwide sample of adults was asked to rate ninety occupations in accordance with prestige [associated with each occupation]. Thus, '*physician*' with the highest prestige occupation, and '*shoe shiner*' was the lowest. In between these came the other professional occupations, clerical and sales occupations, skilled and unskilled workers, etc.

Occupation and Prestige. There is no doubt that *occupations are related to social status* in advanced industrial societies. People in those societies perceive the prestige differences between occupations. Two factors seem to account for greater prestige of some occupations: (*i*) *The functional importance of an occupation to the social system in which it is rated*: and (*ii*) *the scarcity of personnel for the occupation relative to demand*. For example, the occupation of physicians is associated with higher prestige in many societies because of its importance and the scarcity of the physicians to meet societies' actual needs.

Income. Income is a factor in occupational prestige but it is not only factor. One of the tests conducted in U.S.A. has revealed that the majority of people rate occupational prestige not on the basis of money but on something else. It is found that factors such as *responsibility for public welfare and highly specialised training* influence the prestige of an occupation to a great extent.

Costumes. Occupational statuses are often symbolised by various kinds of *costume*. These vary all the way from the complete uniform to a distinctive kind of cap or hat. Policemen, priests and soldiers are, for example, easily distinguishable by differences in dress. In hospitals the white uniforms of the doctors and nurses prevent them from being mistaken for patients and visitors. Briefcases are status symbols for sales representatives, diplomats, professors and attorneys. Rank within an occupation, moreover, may also be designated by differences in dress and *badges* [as it is in the case of the army].

In the modern industrial societies the occupational roles are more complex and the functional expectations are more specifically stated. Occupations or jobs are ranked in terms of number of criteria such as *education-qualifications, higher intelligence and skill, experience and difficulty of performance.*